

Why Did the U.S. Enter World War I?

Weigh the evidence for why the United States abandoned neutrality and entered World War I in 1917 — and decide which cause mattered most.

? Historical challenge

For nearly three years the United States stayed neutral in World War I. Then, in the spring of 1917, it declared war on Germany. Historians agree on the sequence of events but disagree about which cause weighed most. Weigh the evidence, note what conflicts and what is missing, and build a defensible working conclusion.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Zimmermann Telegram (Milestone Documents) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The decoded German proposal of a Mexico–Germany alliance.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the telegram propose?
- Why would it inflame American opinion?

SOURCES 2

Wilson Before Congress – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Wilson's April 1917 war message and the close vote that followed.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does Wilson justify going to war?
- What might a persuasive speech leave out?

SOURCES 3

American Entry into World War I, 1917 – Office of the Historian (State Dept.)

SECONDARY SOURCE

A balanced overview of the converging causes of U.S. entry.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Which causes does this source list?
- How does it help you weigh the evidence?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

Historical question

Why did the United States enter World War I in 1917 — and which cause mattered most?

What we think we know

1 Evidence 1

SOURCE

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

EVIDENCE

WHY IT MATTERS

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

2 Evidence 2

SOURCE

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

EVIDENCE

WHY IT MATTERS

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

3 Evidence 3

SOURCE

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

EVIDENCE

WHY IT MATTERS

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

Conflicting evidence

Missing evidence

Working conclusion

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your evidence cards with a partner. Did you rate the same sources as reliable?
- Did you and your partner weight the same cause as most important? What evidence moved you?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Write a working conclusion answering why the U.S. entered World War I. Cite at least two evidence cards, acknowledge a competing interpretation, and note one limitation of your evidence.